

Check the UK flat before students pay

A plain-language plan for a service that checks UK rental flats for Indian students before they pay: who buys, the competition, the visit checklist, the rules, prices, the ₹3 lakh split and a week-by-week launch plan.

Yes, you can build this business, but keep it small, careful and in England at first. The service is simple. An Indian family pays you about **₹7,999 (about £63)**. A checked local partner in the UK city visits the flat or room with the landlord. The partner shows the student round on a **live video call** and checks the landlord's name against the official owner record. The partner also checks the key legal papers. Within **48 hours** you send a plain report that marks each test green, amber or red. The buyers are real but there are fewer each year. Indian study visas fell **16% to 82,523** in the year to June 2026. By my estimate, only about **10,000 to 24,000** Indian students a year pay for a private room before they have seen it. So plan for about **300 checks in your first year**, not thousands. The closest rival, Kinpany, charges £55 but works **only in London** and takes 2 to 5 working days. Nobody else does all of these together: covers every big UK student city, checks the owner and the papers, does a live call, reports in 48 hours, and sells in rupees through Reels and WhatsApp. After paying the partner, the fees and a referral reward, each check leaves you about **₹1,900**. That means about **8 checks a month** cover your running costs, and about **29 a month** would also pay you ₹40,000. Two legal points shape the whole plan. First, people on a **Student visa cannot be self-employed**, so your partners must hold a Graduate visa, be British or settled, or come from a network like Viewber. Second, **from 1 October 2026 you must check every freelancer's right to work in the UK**. Treat the January 2027 intake as a cheap test. Keep ₹1 lakh untouched. Push hard for the big June to August 2027 season only if your February review says go.

A note on numbers: all money uses £1 = ₹127 (the Wise rate on 3 October 2026) (Wise). Some research notes used ₹127.4 or about ₹115 to the pound. I have redone every conversion at ₹127. "(estimate)" means my own sum or guess, not a published fact.

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Here is the service in plain words. A student in India finds a private flat or a room in a shared house. They usually find it on SpareRoom, OpenRent, Facebook or a WhatsApp group. Before they pay a deposit or sign anything, they send you the advert link. You do some quick checks from India. Then a partner who lives in that UK city meets the landlord at the flat. The landlord opens the door with keys while the student and parents watch live on video. The partner walks through every room, tests the alarms and photographs the safety papers. The partner also sees the landlord's ID, so you can compare the name with the owner shown in the official land records. Within 48 hours the family gets a one-page report. Each test is marked green (fine), amber (be careful) or red (a problem). The family then decides whether to pay. Later, the same service can be sold to students from Nepal, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka, and to Indians already in the UK who are moving to a new city for a job.

The UK police tell students to do exactly this. Action Fraud, the UK's fraud reporting service, tells students: "do not pay any money until you, or a reliable contact, has visited the property". It adds that students arriving from overseas should get a friend or contact to check that the property exists ([Action Fraud](#)). SpareRoom, the biggest UK flat-share website, says never pay a deposit without viewing the room in person ([SpareRoom](#)). A student sitting in Pune or Hyderabad cannot follow that advice alone. Your partner is the "reliable contact" the police are talking about.

The money at risk is large for an Indian family. Victims reported **£4.2 million (about ₹53 crore)** of rental fraud losses in 2023. The average victim lost **£1,720 (about ₹2.18 lakh)**. Rental fraud is one of the five most-reported frauds for people aged 11 to 29 ([Which?](#)). One London case shows the kind of trick your partner would catch. A group of letting companies posted more than **18,000 misleading SpareRoom adverts** and made **£18 million (about ₹229 crore)** between 2016 and 2021. They showed photos of one room and then handed over a worse one, which is called "bait and switch". They took deposits before people had seen the room. The victims included international students ([report on the Tower Hamlets case](#)). Your sales line to parents is therefore simple: **"₹7,999 to protect about ₹2 lakh."**

It is just as important to be clear about what the service is not. It is not a building survey. It is not legal advice. It is not a letting agent. You never collect or pass on rent or deposits. Your reports state facts and never call anyone a "scammer". An earlier quick idea card priced this service at ₹3,999 and suggested using Indian students in the UK as checkers. Fuller research changes both points. A lawful partner plus the official owner record costs about ₹4,800 per visit outside London. And Student visa holders are not allowed to do this kind of freelance work.

Fewer Indian students each year, but 10,000 to 24,000 still rent unseen

The Indian student market peaked in 2023 and is shrinking again in 2026. Be honest with yourself about this from the start.

Period	Indian study visas	What it means
Year to June 2023	about 142,700 (estimate)	The peak (The Tribune)
Year to June 2024	110,006	Down 23% after most students lost the right to bring family (The Tribune)
Calendar year 2025	95,231	India was the biggest country, with 23% of all study visas (Home Office)
Year to June 2026	82,523	Down 16%. India is now second after China (Home Office)

The fall is continuing. Study visa applications from all countries were **down 22%** from January to August 2026 compared with the same months of 2025 (231,600 against 298,500) ([Home Office monthly data](#)). The January intake, your first season, is the smaller of the two intakes, and it is getting weaker. December plus January applications fell from 63,900 for the January 2025 intake to **49,500 for January 2026, down 23%** (my sums from the same Home Office tables). In a survey of universities, **66% had fewer Indian students** starting in January 2026, and master's starters were **down 31%** overall ([Times Higher Education](#)). More changes could push numbers down further. The Graduate visa, which lets students stay and work after their course, drops from 2 years to **18 months** for applications made from 1 January 2027 ([GOV.UK](#)). Universities in England will also pay a **£925 (about ₹1.17 lakh)** charge per international student each year from August 2028 ([ICEF Monitor](#)). My working guess is **65,000 to 85,000** new Indian study visas in 2027 (estimate).

Your buyer is a particular kind of student: a master's student renting a private room. 81% of Indian students come for a master's degree ([Home Office](#)). Most master's courses last one year, so a new group needs housing every year. A survey of 3,698 international students found that master's and research students mostly live in **shared private houses**, not university halls. Only **24%** found their home through a university website. **39% of Indian students** said they were worried about money, the highest of the main countries ([Unipol](#)). That worry matters for pricing. January starters have a harder time: **29%** said finding a home was "much more difficult than expected", against 15% of September starters, because halls are mostly full by January ([Unipol](#)).

Step	Number per year	How I got it
New Indian students	about 80,000	Home Office, year to June 2026
Of these, rent a private room or flat	32,000 to 48,000	40% to 60% (estimate, because most are master's students who rent shared houses)
Of these, pay before seeing it	10,000 to 24,000	30% to 50% (estimate; the rest stay with friends first and view in person)
Of these, January intake	2,000 to 6,000	January is about 13% to 15% of the year's applications
You might win in year one	100 to 700 checks	1% to 3% of those who pay unseen (planning guess)

Other new arrivals add a second, smaller pool. Study visas rose sharply in 2025 for **Nepal (19,553, up 60%), Bangladesh (10,828, up 71%)** and **Nigeria (30,204, up 59%)** ([Home Office](#)). Nepal, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka use similar agents and the same Reels culture, so they are the easiest groups to add next. Nigeria would need separate marketing. Indian nurses are a much smaller group now. Only **4,215** Indian-trained nurses and midwives joined the UK register in 2025–26, **down 54%** ([NMC](#)). The overseas care worker route

has been closed since July 2025 ([Home Office](#)). Indians already in the UK are another option. They received **64,495** Graduate visas in the year to June 2026 ([Home Office](#)). Some of them move city for a first job, and they can pay you in pounds.

A new law in England changed how much money is at risk. From **1 May 2026**, a landlord in England can ask for **no more than one month's rent in advance**, and only **after** the tenancy agreement is signed ([GOV.UK](#)). Before this, international students were often asked for **6 to 12 months' rent up front** ([Goodlord](#)). So each scam now takes less money. But the money that can still go is large. In London, rooms cost about £260 to £300 a week ([University Living](#)). A 1-week holding deposit plus a 5-week deposit is **£1,560 to £1,800 (about ₹2.0 to ₹2.3 lakh)** (estimate). Student unions also warn that landlords may now ask for a **UK guarantor** (a person or company that promises to pay if the tenant does not) ([Durham SU](#)). That gives you a referral product, covered later.

The honest summary: this starts as a business sized for one person, not a big company. About 300 checks a year would mean winning 1% to 3% of the students who rent unseen. Growth beyond that has to come from more cities, more nationalities and extra products, not from the shrinking Indian student number.

Kinpany proves the price in London; the rest of the UK is open

One UK company already does something close to this, and it covers only London. Several others do part of the job.

Who	What they do	Price	What is missing for your customer
Kinpany	Checks the owner on the Land Registry and the shared-house licence, then visits with a 15-point checklist, video, photos and a "go ahead / be careful / walk away" verdict (Kinpany)	£55 (₹6,985) ; 3 flats £139 (₹17,653)	Greater London only. Takes 2 to 5 working days. No live call is mentioned (Kinpany)
Viewber	UK-wide network of checked local people who view property for clients (Viewber)	From £38 + VAT, so £45.60 (₹5,791) (Viewber)	Built for landlords, letting agents and investors. Students and tenants are not mentioned (Viewber)
ViewForYou	Student-run live video-call tours (ViewForYou)	£64.99 (₹8,254), cut from £99.99	Its website did not load on 3 October 2026. It may have closed
Moorhouse Property Services	Views a flat for you: video, checklist and report within 48 hours (Moorhouse)	£39 (₹4,953); up to 3 flats £99 (₹12,573)	One region (the south coast); not aimed at Indian students
Airtasker	You post a task and a stranger views the flat (Airtasker)	Median £30 (₹3,810) ; range £25 to £50	Nobody checks the person. No checklist and no paper checks
Student housing platforms (Amber, UniAcco, University Living, Casita, uhomes)	Check only their own listings, mostly big student blocks	Free to students; landlords pay them commission (Careers360)	Will not check a private flat you found yourself. UniAcco's scam guide simply says "book through UniAcco" (UniAcco)

A few others are worth knowing about. **Let UK Home** offers a "viewing proxy" for Chinese and other international students in London, Manchester and Birmingham. It publishes no price, and it is really a letting agent that also earns from landlords ([Let UK Home](#)). That is a conflict your service avoids. uhomes sends its own team to inspect its own listings, and it earns "commissions paid by landlords" ([uhomes](#)). Some free help also exists. Many student unions will check a tenancy contract for free, but nobody visits the flat ([Worcester SU](#)). Anyone can buy the owner record for £7 (₹889) ([GOV.UK](#)), though few Indian students know it exists. King's College London simply tells students abroad to send a friend ([KCL](#)).

Similar services abroad charge much more than £55. Propzee in Melbourne charges **A\$199 (about ₹13,300)** for a viewing with a report emailed within 8 hours ([Propzee](#)). Gander Tour in New York charges **\$125 (about ₹12,065)** for a live FaceTime tour and report, but it does not check the landlord ([Gander Tour](#)). A one-man New York service charges **\$49 (about ₹4,700)** for video only ([View For You NYC](#)). The pattern is clear: "someone films it for you" is cheap, and checking the landlord as well costs more.

The exact gap is the combination, not any single feature. Kinpany checks the owner, but only in London and without a live call. Moorhouse reports in 48 hours, but in one region. Viewber covers the whole UK, but serves landlords. Nobody found does all six of these together. First, cover every big UK student city, including Hatfield, Luton, Coventry, Leicester, Leeds and Newcastle. Second, work only for the tenant. Third, match the landlord's ID to the official owner and check the safety and deposit papers. Fourth, run a live video call during the visit. Fifth, send a written report within 48 hours. Sixth, sell in India, in rupees, on Instagram and

WhatsApp, in Hindi and regional languages, at call times that suit India. I found no Indian Instagram or WhatsApp service selling paid UK flat checks with a public price. Web search cannot see inside Instagram, though, so spend one evening in your first week searching by hand.

Rivals could move into this gap, so speed and your Indian brand are your defence. Kinpany could expand beyond London. Viewber could start selling to tenants. Amber or UniAcco could add a paid check for outside listings. ViewForYou's apparent closure is a warning sign. Find out whether it failed because too few people wanted the service or because it was badly run.

Fourteen tests, half of them done from India before anyone travels

The checklist is built on England's rules, because all ten universities with the most Indian students are in England. These are BPP, Hertfordshire (Hatfield), East London, Coventry, Bedfordshire (Luton), Greenwich, De Montfort (Leicester), Anglia Ruskin, Northumbria (Newcastle) and Leeds Beckett ([UniAcco](#)). Launch in England. Add Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland only after a lawyer has advised you.

Before the visit: seven desk checks you do from India

These take about 30 to 45 minutes per flat (estimate). Most are free. A red result here can save the cost of a visit, so do them first.

#	Test	How you check it	Red flag
1	Is the advert copied?	Reverse image search of the photos (Google Lens or TinEye (Which?)). Search the address on Rightmove, Zoopla, SpareRoom and OpenRent	The same photos appear under another agent or city
2	Who owns it?	Buy the £7 (£889) title register , the official owner record from HM Land Registry for England and Wales (GOV.UK). If the landlord is a company, look it up free on Companies House	The owner's name differs and there is no written permission to let
3	Is the letting agent real?	Agents must belong to an official complaints scheme (legislation.gov.uk). Agents who hold tenants' money must also have client money protection (GOV.UK). Look up both numbers on the schemes' own websites	Not listed, or the certificate number is fake
4	Is the energy rating legal?	Search the postcode on GOV.UK . A rented home needs an energy rating (EPC) of E or better (GOV.UK)	Rated F or G with no registered exemption
5	Does it need a shared-house licence?	An HMO is a house shared by people from different households. 5 or more people from more than one household need a council licence (GOV.UK). Search the council's public register	It needs a licence and is not on the register
6	Is the money request legal?	Ask for a written list of every payment. Compare it with England's limits (see below)	A "viewing fee", "admin fee" or "reservation fee"; more than the legal caps; rent before signing
7	Is the payment route safe?	Ask for the account name and payment method	Cash, crypto, gift cards, Western Union, an account abroad or in another name (Which?); "pay today or lose it"

At the visit: seven checks the partner does on the live call

The partner visits only with the landlord or agent, at a time the landlord arranged. If people live there now, the landlord must give them **24 hours' written notice** before a visit ([legislation.gov.uk](#)). At the start of the call, the partner says the call is being recorded for the tenant's check and gets the landlord's "yes" on camera. The partner never films current tenants or their belongings without permission.

#	Test	How the partner checks it	Red flag
8	Can they get in?	The landlord or agent opens the door with keys, live on video	"The keys are with a friend" or "I'm abroad, I'll post the keys"
9	Is this person the owner or allowed to let it?	The landlord holds up their ID on camera. Do not record or copy it. Note only "name matches owner record: yes or no"	The names do not match and there is no written permission

#	Test	How the partner checks it	Red flag
10	Does the home match the advert, and is it safe?	Walk through every room. Look for damp and mould. Test the heating, hot water, windows and locks. Press the test button on every alarm. England requires a smoke alarm on every floor and a carbon monoxide alarm in any room with a fixed boiler or fire (GOV.UK)	A different room from the photos, mould, dead alarms, a boiler with no carbon monoxide alarm
11	Are the safety papers there?	Photograph the gas safety record , which must be renewed every year (GOV.UK). Photograph the electrical safety report (EICR, an electrician's check of the wiring), which is needed at least every 5 years and must be given to new tenants before they move in (Wandsworth Council)	Missing or out of date. Write "not provided", not "illegal"
12	How many people live there?	Count the bedrooms and the people	5 or more unrelated people and no licence; overcrowding
13	Will the deposit be protected?	Ask which of the three official schemes will hold it: DPS, mydeposits or TDS (GOV.UK)	"We don't use schemes"
14	What is the area like?	Film the street. Check transport, phone signal, noise and bins	Things the advert hid

A small extra signal is worth noting. In England, a real landlord must check that every adult tenant has the **right to rent**, usually with an online "share code" from their visa ([GOV.UK](#)). A "landlord" who asks for nothing except money is acting informally at best. This is a warning, not proof of a scam.

The report within 48 hours

Keep the report to one page, with photos attached. List all 14 tests, each marked green, amber or red. Use facts only, for example: "The owner named on the title register is X. The person we met gave the name Y." Never write "this is a scammer". That keeps you safer from being sued for damaging someone's reputation. Add timestamped photos and a list of missing documents. End with a scope note: "a visual, non-specialist check on [date]; not a building survey; not a guarantee of the landlord's honesty". Thirty days after the family pays, send a free reminder to check that the deposit is protected. The landlord must protect it **within 30 days**, or a court can order up to **3 times the deposit** to be paid to the tenant. The tenant can check for free on the scheme's website or phone line ([GOV.UK](#)). This free follow-up builds trust, and it is a natural moment to offer the move-in photo record.

England's renting rules since 1 May 2026, in plain words

These rules turn many old scam tricks into clear legal red flags, which makes them perfect Reel material. The Renters' Rights Act became law on 27 October 2025, and most of its changes for tenants started on **1 May 2026** ([GOV.UK roadmap](#)).

Rule in England	What your report checks
Rent in advance: at most 1 month , and only after signing and before the tenancy starts (GOV.UK)	Any request for months of rent, or rent before signing, is red
No bidding. The landlord must publish one asking rent and cannot accept offers above it (same source)	"Offer more and it's yours" is red
Tenancies now roll on month by month, "no-fault" evictions have ended, and tenants can leave with 2 months' notice (GOV.UK roadmap)	A contract that locks a student in for a fixed year is amber; ask a lawyer
Holding deposit: at most 1 week's rent , returned within 7 days in most cases. Main deposit: at most 5 weeks' rent when the yearly rent is under £50,000 (GOV.UK)	Anything above these caps is red
Most fees are banned, including admin and inventory fees. A landlord cannot force a tenant to buy a guarantor service or insurance (same source)	Any extra fee is red

Rule in England	What your report checks
Private student blocks (purpose-built student halls) are exempt from the new tenancy system (GOV.UK roadmap)	Your service is for private houses and flats, not big student blocks

Two points are still uncertain. First, a national landlord register (the "PRS Database") starts rolling out region by region from "late 2026" (same roadmap). I could not confirm whether any area is live yet. Once it is, "Is the landlord on the database?" becomes a strong test. Second, rooms let by a landlord who lives in the same home (a "lodger" arrangement) are usually not covered by these tenancy rules, so the one-month cap may not apply to them. Treat lodger rooms case by case.

Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland have different rules

Topic	Scotland	Wales	Northern Ireland
Biggest deposit	2 months' rent (mygov.scot)	Not re-checked; believed similar to England	1 month's rent (nidirect)
Deposit protection deadline	30 working days, with a Scottish scheme (SpareRoom)	30 days, same schemes as England (GOV.UK)	28 days, with details given within 35 days (nidirect)
Fees	Key money, admin fees and non-refundable holding deposits are illegal (mygov.scot)	Most fees banned; contracts are called "occupation contracts" since December 2022 (gov.wales)	Not researched
Landlord register (free public search)	Required. Search at landlordregistrationscotland.gov.uk . Fine up to £50,000 (£63.5 lakh) for letting without it (mygov.scot)	Required through Rent Smart Wales	Landlord Registration Scheme, searchable by name or address (Newry, Mourne and Down Council)
Owner record and energy rating	Registers of Scotland (cost not checked); its own EPC register	Land Registry, £7; EPC on GOV.UK	Land and Property Services (cost not checked); EPC on GOV.UK
Right to rent check	No	No	No (GOV.UK)

In these three nations, the free landlord register search becomes test number 3. Scotland and Wales also have their own registration rules for letting agents. I could not confirm whether a check service paid by the tenant falls under them. That is another reason to start in England.

Only Graduate-visa holders, British or settled people may do paid visits

The cheapest-looking option, paying Indian students already in the UK per visit, is not allowed.

GOV.UK says Student visa holders "cannot be self-employed" ([GOV.UK](#)). Freelance and gig work counts as self-employment, and breaking the work rules can get a student's visa cancelled ([University of Exeter](#)). Some earlier notes suggested hiring students "within their work-hour limits". That only works if the students are proper employees, as the table shows.

Person	Can they do paid visits as a freelancer?	What to do
Student visa holder	No	Only as an employee, for up to 20 hours a week in term time, through a UK payroll company. That costs about £15 to £35 a week per person (₹1,905 to ₹4,445) (GoForma) or £150 to £550 a month (₹19,050 to ₹69,850) (Employment Hero), plus at least £12.71 (₹1,614) an hour (GOV.UK). Too costly for now
Graduate visa holder	Yes (GOV.UK)	Your best pool. Indians received 90,153 Graduate visas in 2025 (Business Today). The visa cannot be extended and shrinks to 18 months from January 2027, so expect partners to leave
Skilled Worker visa holder	Only some second jobs, mostly in their own skilled field (GOV.UK)	Avoid
British, Irish, settled or pre-settled people	Generally yes (not re-checked in this research)	Check a British or Irish passport, or a share code for others (GOV.UK). Include British Indians, retired people and estate agency staff
Viewber members	Viewber recruits and checks them, including a criminal record check (Viewber)	Use as a backup, after checking that Viewber's terms let you resell its visits under your brand

A new rule started on 1 October 2026: you must check freelancers' right to work too. Section 48 of the Border Security, Asylum and Immigration Act 2025 extends right-to-work checks to businesses that use individual subcontractors and gig workers ([DLA Piper](#)). Fines reach **£45,000 (about ₹57 lakh) per illegal worker**, and £60,000 (₹76 lakh) for repeat breaches ([Capsticks](#)). I could not confirm whether these fines can reach a business based only in India. Do the check anyway. It is free and takes minutes. The partner gives you a share code and their date of birth. You enter them at [GOV.UK](#), which shows the kinds of work the person may do. Save a copy of the result. Also ask each partner for a **basic criminal record check (a "basic DBS")**. It costs **£21.50 (about ₹2,730)**, the partner applies for it, and it usually takes about 3 days ([GOV.UK](#)).

Keep partners truly freelance. Pay per completed visit. Let partners accept or turn down each job. If you control their hours and supervise them closely, the law may treat them as "workers", who are owed the minimum wage and holiday pay ([GOV.UK](#)). Each partner should also hold their own public liability insurance, which covers injury or damage to other people.

Pay partners above the market rate so that good people stay. Viewber's 2025 job ads paid about **£19 (₹2,413)** for a standard 30-minute viewing ([DWP Find a Job](#)). Your job is longer: travel, a 30 to 45 minute visit with a live call, photos of the papers, and filling in the report, about 2 hours in all (estimate). Pay **£25 plus £6 travel (₹3,937)** outside London, where bus fares are capped at £3 a journey until at least March 2027 ([Bus](#)

[News](#)). In London, pay **£32 plus £8 travel (₹5,080)** (estimates). Using Viewber as a backup costs more: at £45.60 per visit, you would keep only about ₹700 on a ₹7,999 check, and its visit may not cover your full checklist. Recruit two partners per city, so that one is always free.

₹7,999 a check leaves about ₹1,900, so eight checks a month cover costs

Sell one main product, at a price that covers the £7 owner record. One research note priced the check at ₹6,999 but left out the £7 Land Registry fee. With that fee included, ₹6,999 leaves too little, and you would need nearly twice as many checks to cover costs. The prices below are my recommendation (estimate).

Product	Price	About in £	What it is
Free Red-Flag Check	₹0	£0	The family sends the advert link on WhatsApp. You run desk tests 1, 6 and 7 in about 10 minutes and offer the paid visit if the advert looks real
Flat Check, outside London	₹7,999	£63	All 14 tests, live call, report within 48 hours or money back
Flat Check, London	₹8,999	£71	The same; London partners and travel cost more
Two flats, same city, same day	₹12,999	£102	One trip for the partner
Founding offer (first 20 customers only)	₹6,999 / ₹7,999 London	£55 / £63	₹1,000 off in return for a video review
Move-in photo record	₹5,999 / ₹6,999 London	£47 / £55	Dated photos and video of the flat's condition on day one
Move-out deposit check	₹5,999 / ₹6,999 London	£47 / £55	Last-day photos compared with the move-in record

This price is fair against what families already pay. ₹7,999 is close to Kinpany's £55 (₹6,985) and ViewForYou's £64.99 (₹8,254), and well below Propzee and Gander Tour (₹12,000 to ₹13,300). Your London price, ₹8,999, is about £16 above Kinpany. You justify that with the live call and the 48-hour promise. Parents already pay study-abroad consultants about ₹10,000 to ₹50,000 ([Ambitio](#), one blog's view), and a UK rent guarantor costs from **£295 (₹37,465)** ([Housing Hand](#)). Do not sell a cheap video-only version. Airtasker already offers that for about £30, and it would pull customers away from your main product.

Here is the money left on each check. Payment fees are Razorpay's 2% plus 18% GST on that fee, which comes to 2.36% ([Razorpay](#)). The other items are estimates.

Cost per check	Outside London (₹7,999)	London (₹8,999)
Payment fee (2.36%)	₹189	₹212
Partner fee	₹3,175 (£25)	₹4,064 (£32)
Partner travel	₹762 (£6)	₹1,016 (£8)
Land Registry owner record	₹889 (£7)	₹889 (£7)
Bank cost of paying the partner in pounds (estimate)	₹100	₹100
Money kept aside for refunds (5%)	₹400	₹450
Left per check	₹2,484	₹2,268
Average referral reward (estimate)	₹500	₹500
Left after referral reward	₹1,984	₹1,768

If 70% of checks are outside London and 30% in London, you keep **about ₹1,900 per check** (estimate). The two-flat check leaves about ₹3,700. Each ₹5,999 add-on visit leaves about ₹1,500. The founding offer leaves about ₹1,550 outside London and ₹1,350 in London before referral rewards. Customers who come through an agent pay the agent's ₹1,000 reward, so a ₹7,999 check through an agent leaves about ₹1,480.

Paid ads cost more than a check earns, so do not rely on them. Study-abroad businesses in India pay about **₹600 to ₹2,000 for each person who sends an enquiry** through Facebook and Instagram ads, and only **3% to 5%** of those people buy ([Sotros Infotech](#)). Even if 1 in 10 of your enquiries bought, each customer would cost you ₹6,000 to ₹20,000 in ads. That is far more than the ₹2,484 a check leaves. Referral rewards are much cheaper: ₹1,000 when an agent sends a customer, ₹500 when a society, creator or senior student does. If about half your sales come through referrers, the average reward is about ₹500 per check (estimate).

Your running costs should stay near ₹15,000 a month (estimate). That covers about ₹4,000 for phone, data, Canva, Google Workspace and a booking page. Add about ₹3,000 for the accountant and legal costs spread over the year, about ₹5,000 to boost your best Reels to people who have already watched you, and about ₹3,000 for finding and training partners. Your break-even point is the number of checks that covers these costs. $₹15,000 \div ₹1,900 \approx 8$ **checks a month**. To pay yourself ₹40,000 a month as well, you need $₹55,000 \div ₹1,900 \approx 29$ **checks a month**, which is realistic only in the June to September peak.

Here is a rough first year, from October 2026 to September 2027 (all estimates). The January season, November to January, might bring 30 to 60 checks. February to May might bring 5 to 10 a month. June to September 2027 might bring 50 to 150 a month if your Reels and agents work. A middle case is about 300 checks. That leaves about **₹5.76 lakh**. After **₹1.8 lakh** of running costs, you have about **₹3.9 lakh before paying yourself**, roughly ₹33,000 a month on average, though most of it arrives in summer. Exchange rates also matter. Your partner costs and the owner record are paid in pounds, about £38 per check outside London. **Every ₹4 rise in the pound cuts about ₹150 from each check.** Forecasters expect ₹122 to ₹131 to the pound in the coming months ([MoneyHop](#)), so review your prices every three months.

Split the ₹3 lakh into four locked boxes

Most first businesses die because they run out of cash or because too few people want what they sell. Global studies of failed start-ups find "no market need" in about 35% to 42% of failures and "ran out of cash" in about 29% to 38% ([LaunchRock](#), summarising [CB Insights](#)). Many Indian start-ups that shut in 2025 had tried to buy growth with paid users and discounts ([Storyboard18](#)). So split the money by stage, and open each box only when the one before it has earned the right.

Box	Amount	What it pays for (estimates)	When you may spend it
1. Set-up	₹75,000	Trademark ₹4,500; CA advice about ₹7,500; UK lawyer fixed-fee review about ₹25,000; UK insurance about ₹30,000; UK data protection fee ₹6,604	October 2026
2. Launch	₹1,00,000	Website, payment page and report template ₹15,000; phone microphone and light ₹5,000; 4 trial checks about ₹20,000; running costs October to January ₹60,000	October 2026 to January 2027, month by month
3. Growth	₹25,000	More partners and Reel boosts for the September 2027 season, topped up by January-season earnings; a UK complaints scheme (about ₹23,600 a year) if the lawyer says you need one	Only after the February 2027 review says go
4. Reserve	₹1,00,000	Nothing in this business	Never. It pays for a restart or your next idea

A few spending rules protect these boxes. Never hold a customer's rent or deposit. That is both a legal rule and a money rule. Pay partners only for completed visits, once a month in pounds against their invoices. Run no paid ads until you know how many people who message you go on to pay, and even then only boost Reels to people who have already watched you. Use monthly software plans, not yearly contracts. Keep the 5% refund money in the bank. Never open Box 4 to "give it one more month". This plan pays you no salary until the summer 2027 peak, so make sure your own living costs are covered from somewhere else.

Register lightly in India; in the UK, buy advice and insurance, not a company

India: four simple steps, and two questions for a CA

Start as a sole proprietorship, which means the business is simply you, trading under a business name. It needs no separate company registration and costs about ₹500 to ₹1,000 in its first year ([incorpX](#)). Register on **Udyam**, the government's free small-business register. It is free and paperless, so use only [udyamregistration.gov.in](#), because fake look-alike sites charge fees ([StudyCafe](#)). Open a separate business current account. Banks usually want two proofs that the business exists, such as Udyam plus GST or a Shop and Establishment certificate ([Kanakkupillai](#)). File a trademark for your brand name for ₹4,500 ([S.S. Rana](#)). You may use TM straight away, but use ® only after registration, or you risk a penalty ([S.S. Rana](#)).

GST (India's goods and services tax) needs a written CA opinion before you launch. A service business normally registers only above ₹20 lakh of sales a year ([Tally](#)). There is one catch. If you buy services from abroad, you may have to pay the GST on them yourself under the "reverse charge" rule, and anyone who must do that has to register whatever their sales ([TaxWink](#)). But for services "directly in relation to" a property, the tax place is where the property is ([KnowYourGST](#)). A UK flat visit may therefore not count as buying services from abroad ([TaxGuru](#)). Your CA's answer decides whether you register for GST from day one. Ask the same CA whether payments from customers abroad in pounds count as exports, which carry no GST. For income tax, a sole proprietor can usually declare **6% of digital receipts** as profit without keeping full accounts. This rule is now in Section 58 of the new Income-tax Act 2025 ([ClearTax](#); [taxconcept](#)). Ask your CA to confirm that it fits this business.

Taking payments in and sending payments out both need care. Razorpay charges 2% plus GST for Indian payments. It charges up to 3% for foreign cards, which you must apply for separately ([Razorpay](#)). Stripe accepts Indian businesses by invitation only ([Stripe](#)). Sending money to UK partners is the harder part. The RBI's Liberalised Remittance Scheme, the yearly limit on what one person can send abroad, allows **US\$250,000** per person, and a sole proprietor does not get a second limit for the business ([RBI](#)). Paying for a business service normally goes through your bank as a business payment backed by the partner's invoice. The bank may ask for Indian tax forms 15CA and 15CB ([Skydo](#)). One review says new Indian Wise users cannot currently send money abroad ([Winvesta](#)). Payoneer received in-principle RBI approval in January 2026 to handle payments into and out of India ([Payoneer](#)). Settle the route with your bank and CA in October, before your first partner invoice arrives. India's new data protection law (DPDP) applies its main duties to businesses from about **13 May 2027** ([AZB & Partners](#)). Write a short privacy notice in English and Hindi now anyway, and collect only what you need.

UK: no company yet, but four protections

You do not need a UK company to start. One costs £100 (₹12,700) to set up online plus £50 (₹6,350) a year ([GOV.UK](#)). It needs a real UK postal address ([GOV.UK](#)) and identity checks for directors ([GOV.UK](#)). Owning a foreign company also adds yearly Indian filings under the overseas investment rules ([Razorpay](#)). Open one later, only if insurers or a complaints scheme will not cover an Indian business, or if the volume of checks makes a UK bank account worth it.

First, never handle tenants' money. Then you do not need client money protection, which is required only for agents who hold tenants' money ([GOV.UK](#)). **Second, the UK data protection fee.** The UK's data regulator, the ICO, charges organisations that use personal information £52 (₹6,604) a year at the smallest size, unless they are exempt ([Lewis Silkin](#)). Take its 10-minute self-assessment ([ICO](#)). UK data law probably

applies to you, because your partners collect landlords' names and video in the UK. A business outside the UK may also need a "UK representative" ([LegalVision](#)). For customers' data, your legal reason to use it is the contract with them. For landlords' data, it is preventing fraud ([ICO](#)). Do not record ID documents, and delete raw video after a fixed time, such as 90 days. **Third, insurance.** Professional indemnity insurance pays if a report contains a costly mistake. One in ten small UK firms paid **£62.72 (₹7,965) a year or less**, and one sole trader's quote was £114.50 (₹14,542) ([Simply Business](#)). Public liability insurance covers injury or damage and costs about **£115 to £155 (₹14,605 to ₹19,685) a year** ([NimbleFins](#)). UK insurers may want a UK business, so also ask an Indian insurer for cover that includes UK claims. **Fourth, the complaints scheme question, which is a grey area.** The law says "lettings agency work" includes acting on instructions from "a person seeking to find a dwelling-house ... to rent" ([legislation.gov.uk](#)). A check service paid by the tenant could fall inside that. If so, you must join a redress scheme, an official complaints service for property firms. Property Redress costs **£155 plus VAT** a year (about ₹23,600) ([Property Redress](#)). The Property Ombudsman costs about £278 a year plus a £74 joining fee (about ₹44,700 in the first year) ([TPO](#)). Never take commissions from landlords or agents. That would make you look like you work for them.

Question	Who to ask	Why it matters
Is my tenant-paid check "lettings agency work"? Must I join a complaints scheme? Can I sell in Scotland and Wales?	UK housing lawyer	Decides a yearly cost and where you may sell
How far can my terms limit my liability for a mistake?	UK lawyer	UK consumer law limits how much you can exclude
Must I register for GST from day one? Are payments from abroad exports? Does the 6% income tax rule fit?	Indian CA	Decides your GST registration and tax bill
Which bank route and purpose code do I use to pay UK partners? Do I need forms 15CA and 15CB?	Your bank and CA	Stops payments to partners getting blocked
Must an India-only business pay the ICO fee or appoint a UK representative?	ICO self-assessment, then the lawyer	£52 a year, plus any representative cost
Will you cover an Indian sole proprietor for UK claims?	Insurance broker	Protects you against one costly mistake

Win customers through Reels, seniors, societies and small agents

Parents pay, but students choose, so speak to both. Make Reels in Hindi, English and, if you can, a regional language. England's new law gives you true, scary, simple stories. "If a landlord in England asks for 6 months' rent before you sign, he is breaking the law" ([GOV.UK](#)). "A holding deposit can be at most one week's rent" ([GOV.UK](#)). "£7 tells you who really owns the flat" ([GOV.UK](#)). "The UK police say: don't pay until someone you trust has visited." End every Reel with the free Red-Flag Check: "send us the link on WhatsApp". Many fake adverts can be spotted in minutes, and the real-looking ones turn into paid visits. Show proof: a sample report, each partner's face and name, a short clip from a live call (with the landlord's permission), and the promise "report within 48 hours or your money back". India is 5½ hours ahead of the UK in winter, so a 10 am UK visit falls in the Indian afternoon, when parents can join.

Where	Why it matters	What you offer
University intake WhatsApp and Telegram groups	Each university and intake gets its own group once offer letters go out. This is where your buyers are	Join only through partners or past customers. Answer questions; never spam
IPLUK and IWLUK (Indian professionals and women in London and the UK)	100,000+ Indians across Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp (Ticket Tailor). Seniors get housing questions every day	A personal code and ₹500 for each paid check
r/IndiansInUK on Reddit	About 7,000 members , mostly asking for advice (GummySearch)	Helpful answers that link to your free check
Indian student societies: INSA (in 45+ UK universities), NISAU UK (free membership) and NHSF	INSA calls itself the largest Indian student group in the UK (Imperial College Union). NISAU signs agreements with universities such as UEL (Careers360) and York (University of York)	₹500 to the society for each paid check that uses its code, a free filmed check for a committee member's flat, and free scam-awareness talks
Small study-abroad agents in your city and in Gujarat, Punjab, Hyderabad, Chennai and Kerala	They decide faster than big chains	₹1,000 per paid check, or the agent buys checks at ₹6,999 and resells them in a package. Put the agent's logo on the report for free
Creators who post about Indian student life in the UK	Their audiences trust them. Search #indianstudentsinuk and city vlogs by hand for 30 creators with 5,000 to 100,000 followers	A free check on their own next flat, filmed as content, plus ₹500 per paid referral
Big chains and platforms (IDP, Leverage Edu, Yocket, University Living)	University Living already signs partners for extras such as airport transfers and SIM cards (University Living)	Approach them from March 2027, once you have about 50 checks and reviews

Agents need a reason to send you a private-flat student. They earn commission when a student books a big student block through a platform. Amber's student ambassadors earn **up to £60 (₹7,620)** per booking ([Amber](#)). A private flat earns them nothing. So your pitch is: "When your student has already chosen a private flat, send them to us. You earn ₹1,000, and if the flat turns out to be a scam, nobody blames you." University international offices are unlikely to recommend a new paid service in year one. Ask only to be listed on their "useful services" page or to speak at their online pre-departure sessions.

Add-on products raise what each family spends, using the same partners.

Add-on	How crowded?	Advice
Move-out deposit check	Not crowded. The move-out report is called "the single most important document" in a deposit dispute (MoveIQ). Disputes go to the deposit schemes' free decision services (Legal Documents)	Your best extra. One-year master's students all move out within a few months of each other, so it is a seasonal product
Move-in photo record	Not crowded for students	Offer it in the day-30 reminder and to students who check in with you on arrival
Plain-English tenancy summary	Not crowded	Possible at ₹1,999, as a summary only and never as legal advice (estimate)
UK rent guarantor	Crowded; Housing Hand from £295 (Housing Hand)	Refer, do not build. Ask the provider for a referral fee
Airport pickup, SIM cards, money exchange	Very crowded; some universities offer free pickup (University of Leicester)	Skip

The launch plan, week by week, from 5 October 2026 to the January 2027 intake

Private rooms are usually advertised only 4 to 8 weeks before the move-in date (estimate). This is because the current tenant must first give notice, which is now **2 months** in England ([GOV.UK](https://gov.uk)). So the January 2027 checks will cluster from **late November to early January**. October is for set-up and trial checks only. The targets below are planning guesses.

Week	Main jobs	Target by the end of the week
1: 5–11 Oct	Pick a brand name and search the trademark register. Register on Udyam (free). File the trademark (£4,500). Start opening the business current account. Book a CA and a UK housing lawyer with the questions above. Take the ICO self-assessment. Search Instagram by hand for Indian rivals. Post 3 Reels	Udyam done; CA and lawyer booked; list of rivals
2: 12–18 Oct	Look for partners in London, Hatfield and Luton, Coventry, Leicester and Leeds through alumni groups, IPLUK and LinkedIn. Sign up free on Viewber to see its prices and terms. Interview candidates, run right-to-work checks and ask for basic DBS checks. Draft the checklist and report template	2 candidates per city; right-to-work results saved
3: 19–25 Oct	Trial checks 1 and 2 (London and Coventry), free, on real flats for a student creator or society committee member, and filmed. Website and Razorpay payment page go live. Get insurance quotes	2 reports sent within 48 hours
4: 26 Oct–1 Nov	Trial checks 3 and 4 (Leicester, then Leeds or Hatfield). Buy insurance. Finish your terms with the scope note once the lawyer replies. Publish a sample report. Start the free Red-Flag Check	Checkpoint 1 (see go/stop rules)
5: 2–8 Nov	Open sales with the founding offer. Pitch 10 local agents. Message the Indian societies at Coventry, De Montfort, Hertfordshire, UEL, Greenwich, Leeds Beckett and Northumbria	First paid check booked
6: 9–15 Nov	Get into January intake groups through partners and trial customers. List 30 creators and pitch 10	3 paid checks; 20 free Red-Flag Checks
7: 16–22 Nov	Make Reels about the 1 May law. Pitch 10 more agents. Start a weekly Instagram live Q&A	5 paid checks
8: 23–29 Nov	Review the first reports with partners and fix slow steps. Ask every customer for a video review	8 paid checks; 5 referral partners signed. Checkpoint 2 on 30 Nov
9: 30 Nov–6 Dec	The peak begins. Add a second partner in your busiest city. Post daily Stories	12 paid checks
10: 7–13 Dec	Peak. Share customer stories (with permission)	18 paid checks
11: 14–20 Dec	Peak. Warn families that UK holidays slow landlords down; take bookings from 28 December onwards	24 paid checks
12: 21–27 Dec	UK Christmas: visit only where landlords agree. Prepare a pound-priced offer for students who arrive without housing	27 paid checks
13: 28 Dec–3 Jan	Last-minute rooms. Keep the 48-hour promise	30 paid checks
14: 4–10 Jan	The last rush before term	36 paid checks

Week	Main jobs	Target by the end of the week
15: 11–17 Jan	Students arrive. Sell checks in pounds to those staying in temporary rooms. Launch the move-in photo record	40 paid checks
16: 18–24 Jan	Collect video reviews. Pay partners	10 video reviews
17: 25–31 Jan	Make a "January season results" Reel. Count everything	Numbers ready for review
18–19: 1–14 Feb	Hold the January-season review (go/stop rules)	Decision written down by 15 Feb

The September 2027 plan: build in spring, sell hard in summer

September is the big intake. About **70%** of a year's study visa applications come between June and September, with the peak in August ([Home Office](#)). Scams also peak in July and August, when students rush to find a home ([The Negotiator](#), older data). Use the quiet spring to build the partner network and the referral network.

When	What students are doing	Your main jobs	Target (estimate)
February 2027	January students settle in	Hold the review. If it says go, open Box 3. Sell in pounds to new arrivals	Decision by 15 Feb
March–April	September students get offers and book halls	Sign creator deals. Agree September offers with INSA, NISAU and the university societies. Sign 15 to 20 local agents. Pitch University Living and the big chains with your reviews. Add partners in Manchester, Birmingham, Newcastle and Nottingham. Recruit British and settled partners too, because new Graduate visas last only 18 months	2 partners in each of 8 to 10 cities
May	Visa season; pre-departure events across India	Run stalls and talks at pre-departure events. Launch the move-out check for students already in the UK. Finish your privacy notice and data deletion rules before India's DPDP duties start in mid-May	10 move-out bookings
June–August	The peak hunt for private rooms	Put all your Reel effort here. Do Red-Flag Checks every day. Keep a backup partner in each city and Viewber for overflow. Boost Reels only to people who already watched. Checkpoint on 15 July	50 to 150 checks a month
September	Arrivals; last year's master's students move out	Sell move-in records and move-out checks. Review the year. Decide on a UK company, Scotland and Wales (after legal advice), and adding Nepali, Bangladeshi and Sri Lankan students	About 300 checks in year one

Go/stop rules and the main risks

Write these rules down now, before you spend anything, and follow them even when you feel hopeful.

Checkpoint	Go if	Stop or change if
31 October 2026 (set-up)	Lawful partners in at least 3 of the 5 first cities; 4 trial reports sent within 48 hours; the lawyer sees no licence you cannot afford	Fewer than 3 cities: start with London plus Coventry and Leicester, and use Viewber as backup. If the lawyer says you need a licence or a UK company, pause and cost it before spending more
30 November 2026 (first sales)	5 or more paid checks and 20 or more free Red-Flag Checks	Fewer than 5: change the message, price or channel once, then judge again on 31 December
15 February 2027 (January season)	30 or more paid checks; 9 in 10 reports on time; no more than 1 in 10 refunded; about ₹1,900 left per check; 3 or more referral partners who each sent 2 or more customers. Then open Box 3	10 to 29 checks: stay lean, keep Box 3 shut, and test again in June. Under 10 checks, or Box 2 empty: stop, write down what you learned, and keep Box 4
15 July 2027 (peak)	50 or more paid checks since 1 June	Under 20 since 1 June: finish the booked checks, then close or keep it as a small side service
At any time	—	A partner harms someone or breaks the law; you get a legal complaint you cannot fix; any spending would touch Box 4

Risk	What could happen	What you do
The market keeps shrinking	Indian visas are already down 16%, the January intake is weaker, and the Graduate visa gets shorter	Keep costs low. Add Nepali, Bangladeshi and Sri Lankan students and move-out checks
Families feel safer under the new law	The one-month cap means less money up front in England	Sell the deposit, holding deposit and bait-and-switch risks; refer guarantors
Legal grey area	Your service may count as "lettings agency work"	Lawyer before the first paid visit; England first; never hold money; never take landlord commissions
Partner problems	No-shows, weak reports, misconduct, or illegal working with a £45,000 fine	Right-to-work and DBS checks; 2 partners per city; a fixed checklist; Viewber as backup
Mistakes in a report	A missed mould problem, or a landlord who feels defamed	Scope note, facts-only wording, photo evidence, insurance
Data leak	Landlord ID or videos get out	Never record ID; delete raw video after 90 days; keep a privacy notice
Rivals copy you	Kinpany leaves London, Viewber sells to tenants, or platforms add a paid check	Speed, an Indian brand, many cities, a strong referral network
The pound rises	Partner costs rise about ₹150 per check for every ₹4	Review prices every three months
Quiet months	February to May may bring only 5 to 10 checks a month	Box 3, add-ons and ₹15,000 running costs
Payments to partners get stuck	Your bank cannot easily pay UK freelancers	Agree the route with your bank and CA in October

Conclusion

The visits themselves are not what makes this business hard to copy. Viewber, Airtasker and Kinpany can all send someone to a door. What they lack is the trust of Indian families, Hindi and regional-language Reels, and a referral web of seniors, societies and small agents. Your selling and Reels skills are therefore the core of the business, not a side task, and the UK partner network is the part you can rent. England's new renting law cuts both ways. It shrinks the money each scam can take. It also hands you clear, legally true warnings, such as "six months up front is now illegal", that make strong content and turn worry into bookings.

The January 2027 season is a cheap test of whether people pay, not a test of the full market. The real decision is whether June to August 2027 brings 50 or more checks a month. If it does, grow sideways: add Nepali, Bangladeshi and Sri Lankan students, more cities and move-out checks, rather than spending on ads. If it does not, stop with ₹1 lakh still in the bank. Settle two open questions before the first paid visit: whether a tenant-paid check counts as letting agency work, and how you will legally pay UK partners from India. Everything else in the plan can be adjusted as you go.